

Planners Criticize Pacoima's 'Lack of Pride,' Development

PACOIMA — The city planning staff has struck a stiff blow at what it calls a lack of civic pride, substandard home maintenance and lack of a coherent structure of business development in the central district here.

In a 48-page report giving recommendations for development of the area, the staff urged steps to end the "rambling, outmoded strip commercial pattern of Van Nuys Blvd." in favor of more compact community shopping centers.

It also called for continuing efforts to improve the area's entire street system, including sidewalks and trees, and for the development of a civic and cultural center to give Pacoima a degree of unity.

The staff's recommendation for decreasing the strip zoning is expected to run into opposition from

the Pacoima Chamber of Commerce, which has called for a deepening of the existing commercial zones on both Van Nuys Blvd. and Laurel Canyon Blvd.

The City Planning Commission will discuss the 11 alternatives for the Van Nuys-Laurel Canyon axis of Pacoima and the Osborne St.-Eldridge Ave. area of Lake View Terrace on Thursday, at 9:30 a.m. in Room 561-A of the downtown City Hall.

Key points in the report include: "Van Nuys Blvd. . . . is characterized by a rambling, shallow strip pattern of commercial uses . . . varying from banks to hamburger stands, including an unusual number of small business and service shops.

"Minimal offstreet parking facilities.

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ties have been provided. Numerous store fronts appear vacant and several others are in disrepair. . . In general, the physical image conveyed by the locale is somewhat depressing.

Poor State of Repair

Laurel Canyon Blvd. is in some instances in a poor state of repair, (and) moreover, curbs and sidewalks are conspicuously minimal. Most of the dwellings are of an older vintage and many homes and yards, especially in the R-2 (duplex) zones, show sign of neglect.

"Generally, the area conveys a lack of civic pride.

"Pacoima appears to lack a vital community image, with no apparent nucleus or focal point.

"The range of housing types . . . is unusually narrow for a community of this size. It has a detrimental effect . . . and is reflected in low purchasing power. Substandard home maintenance is widespread and borders on total neglect in some sectors."

The staff noted that more apartments are needed in central Pacoima, although the picture is clouded by the fact that the Valley as a whole has enough apartment-zoned land to last 28 years.

The staff proposed two alternatives for the Laurel Canyon-Van Nuys axis:

One alternative shows a 40-acre shopping center at the intersection, with a commercial - manufacturing center at Van Nuys and San Fernando Rd.

The other alternative calls for a 28-acre shopping site at the first location and a 12-acre commercial site at the second.

Mall Asked

The first option calls for closing Pinney St. between Laurel Canyon and Amboy Ave. for a shopping mall.

In both cases, the commercial strip pattern between the two centers would be downgraded to an apartment zone, a solution which the report said "property owners often find unpalatable."

The staff proposes nominal expansion of the Laurel Canyon-Paxton St. and Laurel Canyon-Terra Bella commercial corners.

The staff proposes the new restricted density multiple (RD-2) zones for most of Laurel Canyon Blvd. between Daventry and Filmore Sts. on the north and Pierce and

Remington Sts. on the south, a plan which contrasts sharply with the chamber of commerce's proposal of heavier-density apartment zoning.

In Lake View Terrace, the staff proposes a 22-acre community commercial complex at Foothill Blvd. and Osborne St.

The site would furnish "a convenient focal point

for Lake View Terrace without basically disturbing the exclusive residential nature of this community."

The Lake View Terrace-Pacoima - Panorama City district has a population of 91,000, which is expected to grow to 133,000 by 1980.

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